

In the Pink of HEALTH

Women are a major force in the healthcare sector.
Can this strong participation open the doors to wider leadership? BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

T

HE SIGHTS AND SOUNDS of healthcare in India—from busy nursing stations to diagnostic labs humming with machines and outpatient queues threading through hospital corridors—leave little doubt about who keeps the system running. Women are present everywhere on the floor. They staff wards, run clinics, manage quality systems, and deliver care, driving daily operations across the health system even as their representation at the top continues to grow.

According to World Health Organization data published in 2024, women make up about 67% of the global healthcare workforce but hold around 25% senior leadership roles. In India, the pattern is similar. A 2023 study by Dasra, a Mumbai-based philanthropic organisation, found that women occupy roughly 18% of senior leadership positions in the health sector despite accounting for a large share

of its operational and clinical workforce. A 2024 assessment published in PLOS Global Public Health found that 19.5% of India's major medical associations are led by women. These figures underline the scale of women's contribution and the growing opportunities for leadership as the sector evolves.

WHERE THEY STAND

The Udaiti Foundation's Women's Formal Employment Tracker 2024 reported that women's representation is highest in hospitals and laboratories at 41%. The reasons women enter healthcare in such large numbers are practical as well as historical, say women leaders. Women were traditionally encouraged to take up nursing and caregiving roles. In the 20th century, medical and life-science education became more open to women.

"Healthcare has always been an en-